

data

Dear Abby Data

Data used in The Pudding essay [30 Years of American Anxieties: What 20,000 letters to an advice columnist tell us about what—and who—concerns us most](#), published in November 2018.

This includes questions publicly available on <https://www.uexpress.com/>, as well as a number of questions from the mid-1980s, obtained through digital copies of newspapers which included Dear Abby questions.

- Time span of data: 1985–Fall of 2017

Data have been augmented to include sentiment analysis information. Sentiment analysis is a text analysis method that aims to quantify the mood/sentiment of a text.

A basic sentiment analysis was performed in which each word of the question received a sentiment score. Different sentiment *lexicons* are available and provide different measures of sentiment for a broad range of English words.

- The `afinn` lexicon assigns each word a score between -5 and 5, with negative scores indicating negative sentiment and positive scores indicating positive sentiment. To summarize the sentiment scores over all words in a question, 3 measures were computed:
 - Add up the values for all words for `afinn_overall` —this gives an overall sense of the sentiment for a question.
 - Add up the values for just positive words for `afinn_pos` —this gives a measure of the magnitude of positive sentiment.
 - Add up the values for just negative words for `afinn_neg` —this gives a measure of the magnitude of negative sentiment.
- The `bing` lexicon categorizes words in a binary way: positive or negative.
 - `bing_pos` gives the fraction of positive words in a question. ($1 - \text{bing_pos}$ gives the fraction of negative words.)

Variable	Description
year	Letter publication year
month	Letter publication month
day	Letter publication day

Variable	Description
url	URL where question may be found alongside the answer
title	Title of the column wherein the letter appeared
letterId	Number of the letter, when multiple letters appear
question_only	Text of the question
afinn_overall	Overall sentiment by the <code>afinn</code> lexicon
afinn_pos	Magnitude of positive sentiment using <code>afinn</code>
afinn_neg	Magnitude of negative sentiment using <code>afinn</code>
bing_pos	Fraction of words with positive sentiment using <code>bing</code> lexicon